

Cold Calling Playbook & Checklist

A step-by-step guide for booking discovery demos with independent sponsors and Fund I private equity firms — part of the 90-day plan to sign our first 10 paying customers.

Prepared for the Outbound / Intern team · August 2026 · Internal use only

1 Your Mission

PE OS is *the AI analyst for deal teams that don't have analysts*. Independent sponsors and small PE firms scroll through hundreds of CIMs a year with no support staff — they spread financials and write IC memos on nights and weekends. We fix that. Your job is **not to sell on the phone** — it's to find the firms who feel this pain and get 15–20 minutes on the founder's calendar to show them the product.

25/wk

new outbound touches
(call + LinkedIn)

30%+

of connected calls should
end in a booked meeting

10

paying customers is the
90-day finish line

Day 60

checkpoint — flag the
founder if <3 firms have
paid by then

2 Who You're Calling

Ideal profile

Primary Independent sponsors, ETA searchers, and Fund I PE firms in the **US lower middle market**. Usually a 2–4 person team. No dedicated analyst. Currently running deal flow out of Gmail, Excel, and Dropbox.

Why they'll take the call

They see 200–500 teasers/CIMs a year and screen, spread, and memo them by hand — 3–6 analyst-hours per CIM, 20–40 hours per IC memo. The alternative to PE OS isn't "another tool," it's hiring a \$150K/yr analyst they can't yet afford.

Where to find them

- ☐ Searchfunder.com — searcher/sponsor directory and forums
- ☐ LinkedIn Sales Navigator — filter by title (Managing Partner, Principal, Independent Sponsor, Search Fund) + firm size 2–10
- ☐ Attendee/speaker lists from iGlobal Forum and McGuireWoods search-fund events
- ☐ Referrals from anyone who's already taken a call — always ask "who else should have this?"

3 Before You Dial

- ☐ Confirm you're calling in the **9:00–11:00am US Eastern** window — this is when the target ICP actually picks up (6:30–8:30pm IST if calling from India)
- ☐ Spend 2 minutes on LinkedIn / the firm's website: their name, firm, fund size, and one recent deal or post to reference
- ☐ Check PE OS (our own CRM) for any prior contact with this person or firm before you call — never cold-call someone we've already touched without knowing it
- ☐ Have the script and objection table (below) open, but don't read it word-for-word — sound like a person, not a script

4 The Call Script

Goal of every call: qualify the pain, then ask for a specific calendar slot. Five steps.

STEP 1 — OPENER (10 SECONDS)

"Hi [Name], this is [Your name] — I know I'm calling out of nowhere, do you have 30 seconds?"

Wait for a yes. If they're busy: "No problem — is there a better 2 minutes tomorrow, or should I just send something over?" Never push past a genuine "not now."

STEP 2 — VALUE-FIRST MINI-PITCH

"We built PE OS for deal teams that don't have analysts — it screens CIMs, spreads the financials, and drafts your IC memo, so partners aren't doing it on Saturdays. Is CIM triage something that eats up your team's time right now?"

STEP 3 — DISCOVERY (LISTEN MORE THAN YOU TALK)

"How many teasers or CIMs are you seeing a month right now?" · "Who's doing the spreading and the IC memo today — you, a partner, someone else?" · "What are you using to track it all — Excel, email, something else?"

STEP 4 — REFLECT THE PAIN, TAILOR THE PITCH

"That's exactly who we built this for — [reflect back what they said]. Most firms like yours cut CIM screening from hours to minutes and get a first-draft IC memo the same day."

STEP 5 — ASK FOR THE MEETING (BE SPECIFIC, NOT OPEN-ENDED)

"I'd love to show you 15 minutes on your next live CIM — would Tuesday at 4pm or Thursday at 10am work better?"

Always offer two specific times, not "whenever works for you." Confirm email, send the calendar invite before you hang up if possible.

Voicemail (use if no answer — keep it under 20 seconds)

"Hi [Name], [Your name] from PE OS — we help deal teams like yours screen CIMs and draft IC memos without hiring an analyst. I'll follow up by email, but call me back anytime at [number]."

5 Objection Handling

Objection	Response
"We already manage this fine in Excel."	"Totally get it — most of our customers said the same thing before their first 300-CIM year. It's less about replacing Excel and more about not spending Saturdays spreading financials by hand. Worth 15 minutes to see if it'd actually save you time?"
"We don't have budget for new tools."	"Fair — we're not priced like enterprise software. Plans start at \$299/month, which is less than one analyst-hour a week. And we've got a founding-customer rate for the first 20 firms — 40% off, locked for 24 months."
"How is this different from DealCloud or just using ChatGPT?"	"DealCloud starts around \$30–50K/year before implementation — built for firms with dedicated ops teams. PE OS is live the same day, at a fraction of the cost, for teams that don't have an analyst or an IT department. And unlike a general chatbot, it's built specifically to read CIMs, spread financials, and draft IC memos."
"Is our data / our CIMs secure?"	"Yes — we never train on customer data, and we can walk you through our security page and data handling on the call. Happy to send our security whitepaper before you decide anything."
"Just send me some info, I'll take a look."	"Happy to — I'll send it right after this call. Can I also grab 15 minutes on your calendar now so we're not just leaving it to an inbox? If it's not useful once you see it, no hard feelings."
"Not interested."	"No worries at all, appreciate you taking the call. Quick ask — is there anyone else in your network doing similar deal work who might find this useful?" (Always exit gracefully — referrals matter more than any single "no.")

6 Follow-Up Cadence

Nobody books a meeting off one touch. Run this sequence for every contact who doesn't say a hard "no":

Day	Action
Day 0	Call. If no answer, leave voicemail + send LinkedIn connection request same day.
Day 1	Short, personal follow-up email referencing the call attempt (2–3 sentences, no attachments).
Day 3	LinkedIn message if they've accepted the connection.
Day 5	Second call attempt — try a different time of day than the first.
Day 8	Value-add touch: share something useful (a relevant post, a case study, the free CIM analyzer link) — no ask attached.

Day 12

Final call attempt or "breakup" email: "Should I close the loop on this, or is timing just off right now?" Often gets a reply either way.

No lead should go more than 5 days without a touch until it's marked Meeting Booked, Not Now, or Disqualified.

7 After Every Call — Log It

We build a CRM — use it on ourselves. Log every call in PE OS the same day, without exception:

- ☐ Outcome (Connected / No Answer / Voicemail / Wrong Number / Not Interested)
- ☐ One-line note on what they said (their pain, their objection, their tone)
- ☐ Status tag: New → Attempted → Connected → Meeting Booked → Not Now → Disqualified
- ☐ Next action + date (this drives the follow-up cadence above — don't rely on memory)

8 Do's and Don'ts

Do	Don't
✓ Research each prospect for 2 minutes before dialing	✗ Read the script word-for-word like a robot
✓ Lead with their pain, not our feature list	✗ Discuss pricing before you've asked a single discovery question
✓ Offer two specific meeting times, not "whenever"	✗ Use fake urgency or pressure tactics
✓ Be upfront that we're an early-stage, founder-led product	✗ Claim certifications we don't have yet (say "SOC 2 on our roadmap," never "SOC 2 certified")
✓ Log every call the same day	✗ Call outside 9am–6pm their local time, or on weekends
✓ Always ask for a referral, even on a "no"	✗ Leave a lead untouched for more than 5 days

9 Daily Checklist

- ☐ Pull today's 5 targets from the list (Searchfunder / LinkedIn Sales Nav / event list)
- ☐ 2-minute research per target before dialing
- ☐ Make calls inside the 9–11am ET window
- ☐ Log every call in PE OS same day — outcome, note, next action + date
- ☐ Send same-day follow-up email to anyone reached but not ready to book
- ☐ Send LinkedIn connection request to everyone called, reached or not
- ☐ End of day: report your numbers to the founder — calls made, connected, meetings booked

10 Weekly Checklist

- ☐ 25 new outbound touches logged for the week
- ☐ Follow-up cadence maintained for every prior week's leads — nothing untouched >5 days
- ☐ Weekly numbers reviewed against target: 30%+ of connected calls → booked meeting
- ☐ Target list refreshed with new names sourced (Searchfunder / LinkedIn / referrals)
- ☐ Any recurring objection the script doesn't cover flagged back to the founder

Quick Reference Card

Core message

"The AI analyst for deal teams that don't have analysts. Screen every CIM, draft IC memos in hours, and run your pipeline in one place — priced per deal, not per seat."

One-liners vs. alternatives

vs. DealCloud + ToltIQ: *"Enterprise price, enterprise implementation. PE OS is live the same day, at a tenth of the cost."*

vs. Meridian / DiligenceSquared / Keye: *"They sell AI diligence to firms that already have platforms and analysts. PE OS is the whole stack for firms that have neither."*

vs. Excel + Dropbox + Gmail: *"You didn't raise a fund to spend Saturdays spreading financials."*

Pricing (for when they ask)

Tier	Price	Who it's for
Free — CIM Analyzer	\$0	2 CIM analyses/mo — the easy first yes
Sponsor	\$299/mo (\$249 annual)	Independent sponsors, searchers, Fund I — 10 analyses/mo, ≤5 users
Fund ★	\$999/mo (\$833 annual)	Sub-\$500M funds — 30 analyses/mo, firm research agent
Firm	from \$2,500/mo	\$300M–\$1B AUM — custom, SOC 2 report, API

Founding offer: first 20 firms get 40% off, locked for 24 months, in exchange for a logo, a quote, and a monthly feedback call.

Proof points to mention

Live interactive demo deal (Luktara) — we can walk them through a real CIM on the call

Security whitepaper + trust page — no training on customer data

Founder-led, fast to respond, shaping the roadmap around early customers